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What is acceptance criteria? Examples and best practices

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Key Takeaways

- Acceptance criteria are predefined requirements and conditions that a product or task must meet to be marked as complete and accepted by the user.
- These specific standards eliminate ambiguity by providing a clear "definition of done" for developers and quality assurance teams.
- Establishing these benchmarks during the planning phase ensures that the final output aligns perfectly with customer expectations.
- Document clear and measurable standards for every user story to ensure your team delivers exactly what the client requested.

Acceptance criteria fosters clear communication and helps define expectations. They outline the specific conditions a feature or user story must meet to be truly complete, and are sometimes referred as "Definition of Done."

What's the secret to building software that actually delivers? If you’re a [product manager](#) or product owner, nailing acceptance criteria is key to building features that hit the mark.

Without clear acceptance criteria, teams risk confusion, missed goals, and wasted effort. But what exactly are acceptance criteria, and how do you write them well?

In this article, we’ll break down what acceptance criteria are, real-world examples, how they differ from user stories, why they matter for your development process, and how to write your own.

User story map template

What is acceptance criteria?

Acceptance criteria are the conditions that a product, user story, or increment of work must satisfy to be complete. They’re a set of clear, concise, and testable statements that focus on providing positive customer results.

Instead of focusing on how you reach a solution, acceptance criteria are the final desired outcome of the task.

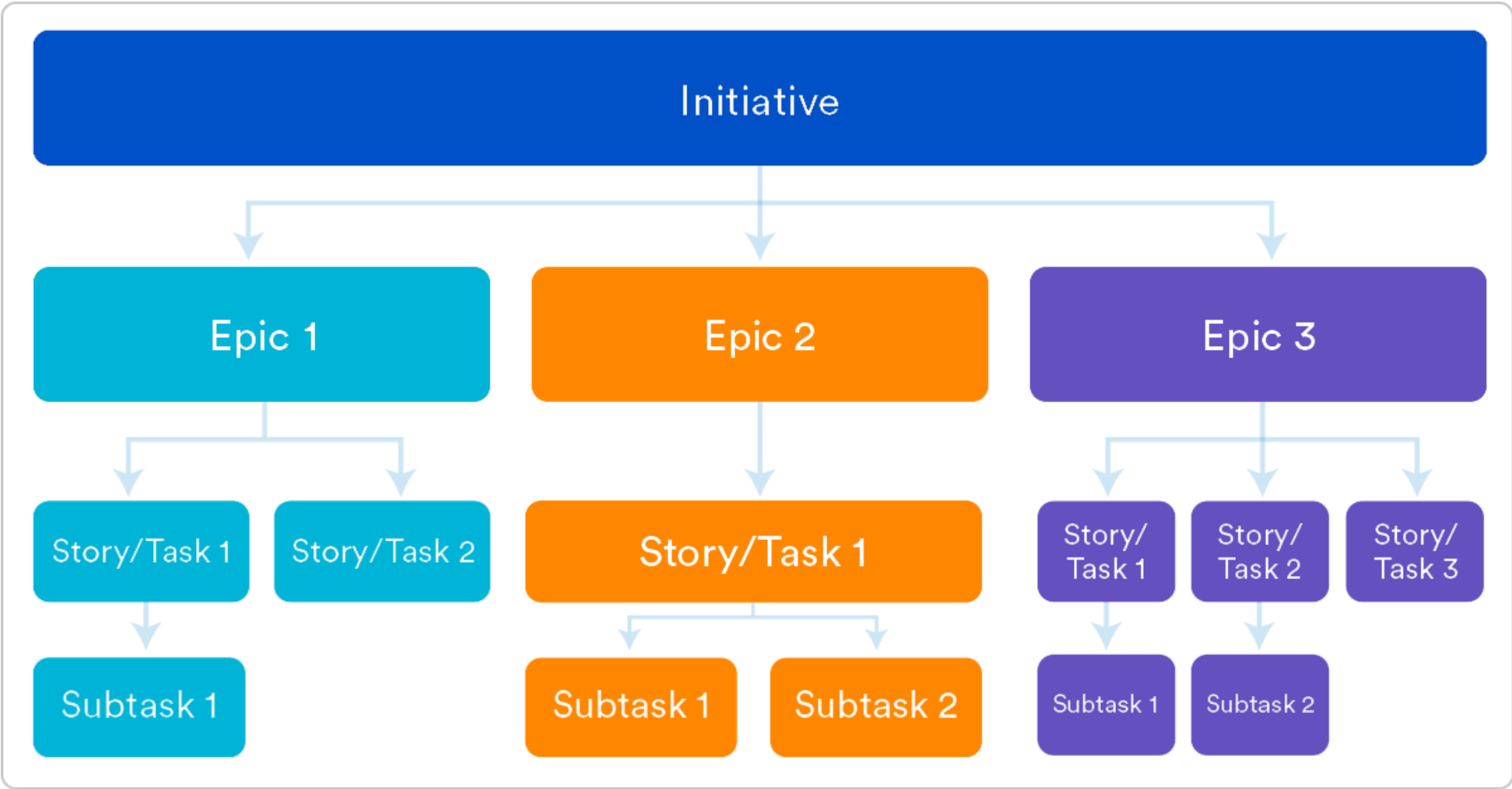
They are seen as predefined requirements in [Agile methodologies](#)—specifically a user story must satisfy to be considered complete. They also work as a type of Agile requirements documentation that outline certain conditions that must be met for successful delivery.

Acceptance criteria vs. user story

Acceptance criteria and [user stories](#) are often discussed together, but they play fundamentally different roles in product development. Understanding this distinction is critical to writing a backlog that is both user-centered and delivery-ready.

- **User stories articulate the “why”** and communicate the purpose and value of a feature from the user’s perspective.
- **Acceptance criteria define “what success looks like”** and translate that purpose into explicit, verifiable requirements for implementation.

Well-crafted user story captures the customer need, the intended behavior, and the underlying motivation. This framing anchors backlog items in real user value and provides essential context for [backlog grooming](#) and prioritization.



For example, user stories could be:

- As a customer, I want to search for products by name so I can easily find what I’m looking for.

This story sets direction. It does not specify implementation.

However, acceptance criteria convert intent into clear, testable conditions that determine whether the story is done. They align your team on scope, eliminate ambiguity, and provide a measurable standard for QA and stakeholders. This might include:

- The search function returns results that exactly match the entered product name.
- The search function returns results that partially match the entered product name.
- Results are displayed in a clear, organized, and user-friendly format.

Together, they ensure your team builds the right thing—and builds it right.

Characteristics of good acceptance criteria

High-quality acceptance criteria share several key characteristics that make them easy to understand, validate, and effectively guide delivery. Some common characteristics include:

Clarity and conciseness

Say exactly what you mean, and say it simply. Write acceptance criteria in plain, unambiguous language that all stakeholders—engineering, QA, design, and product—can interpret the same way.

Keep them tight and outcome-focused. Avoid jargon and any phrasing that leaves room for interpretation.

Testability

Every criterion must be objectively verifiable. Each criterion should map cleanly to one or more executable tests that objectively confirm whether the requirement is met.

Testability removes all subjectivity and keeps everyone honest about what “done” really means.

Outcome

Describe the result, not the recipe. Strong criteria explain what the user should experience, not the technical steps required to build it.

This gives engineers room to problem-solve while ensuring the final behavior aligns with user expectations.

Measurability

Where possible, quantify expectations to create a definitive pass/fail threshold. This is where precision accelerates testing and reduces rework.

Replace vague statements like: "The results page should look good. Instead, use measurable statements like: Each product image displays at a minimum resolution of 300×300 pixels."

Independence

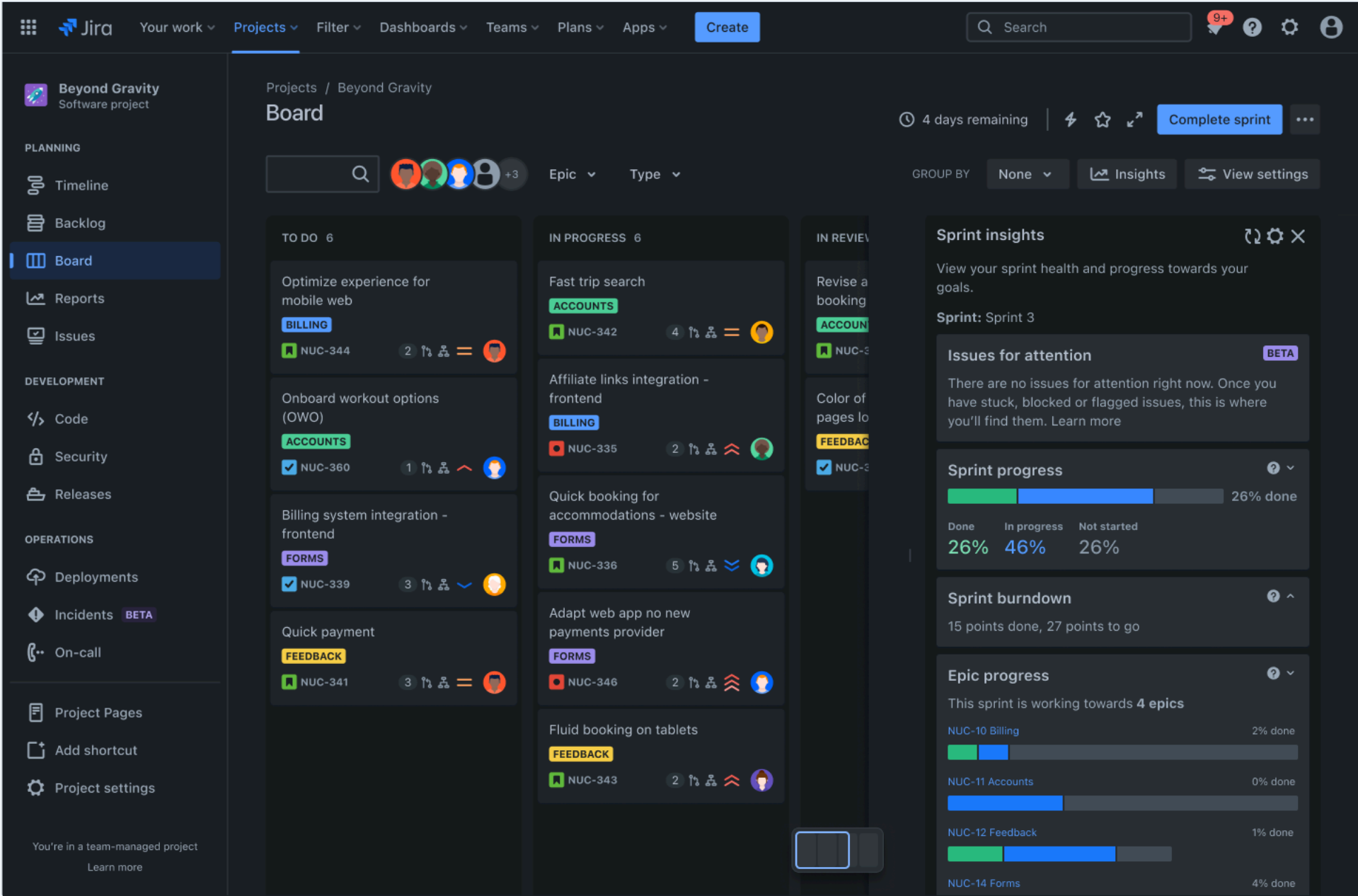
Each criterion should stand on its own. Independent criteria simplify testing, reduce coupling, and make it easier to diagnose issues when something fails.

If criteria rely on one another to make sense, you probably need to rewrite them.

Why do you need acceptance criteria?

Acceptance criteria are one of the most powerful tools you have to drive clarity, reduce churn, and ensure you actually deliver the thing you *thought* you were building. Here’s why they deserve a permanent spot in your process:

- **Alignment and shared understanding:** When you spell out what success looks like, everyone—from engineering to QA to stakeholders—gets on the same page, without assumptions that lead to surprises. Acceptance criteria serve as the shared contract for what you’re building and why.
- **Reduced ambiguity and rework:** A clear [definition of done](#) (DoD) is the fastest path to preventing rework. Vague expectations lead to endless iterations; explicit criteria keep subjectivity (and scope creep) from happening. Clarity upfront is always cheaper than correction later.
- **Improved testing efficiency:** Well-defined acceptance criteria basically hand QA a testing blueprint. They translate directly into verifiable steps, making it simple to confirm whether the feature meets expectations or easily spot where it doesn’t.
- **Enhanced project management:** For [project managers](#), acceptance criteria are gold. They break a feature into measurable checkpoints, making progress visible and reducing risk. Every criterion checked off is a tangible step toward delivery.
- **Increased stakeholder satisfaction:** When features consistently meet expectations, stakeholders trust the process—and the product. Clear acceptance criteria set realistic expectations, minimize ambiguity, and help deliver outcomes that genuinely satisfy user needs.



Acceptance criteria bridge the gap between vision and execution. They turn intent into alignment, alignment into action, and action into reliable delivery.

If you want your teams to move fast *and* build the right thing, acceptance criteria are non-negotiable.

How to write acceptance criteria

Crafting well-defined acceptance criteria is essential for successful software development. Here are some key steps and tips for guidance:

1. Start with the user story

Refer to the user story connected to the acceptance criteria. This ensures that the criteria tie to the desired functionality.

2. Determine the outcomes

Express the user experience and expected outcomes criteria. What should the feature achieve for the user? Avoid getting bogged down in technical implementation details.

3. Establish overall testability

Ensure each criterion translates into a clear and verifiable test. This allows for an objective evaluation of whether the feature meets the requirements.

4. Decide the measurability

Whenever possible, quantify the criteria using measurable terms. This facilitates a clear pass/fail determination during testing.

5. Focus on independence

Aim for independent criteria that you can test in isolation. This streamlines the testing process and avoids dependencies.

Consider incorporating User acceptance testing (UAT) criteria alongside the development team's criteria. UAT criteria focus on ensuring the feature meets expectations from a usability standpoint.

6. Promote collaboration

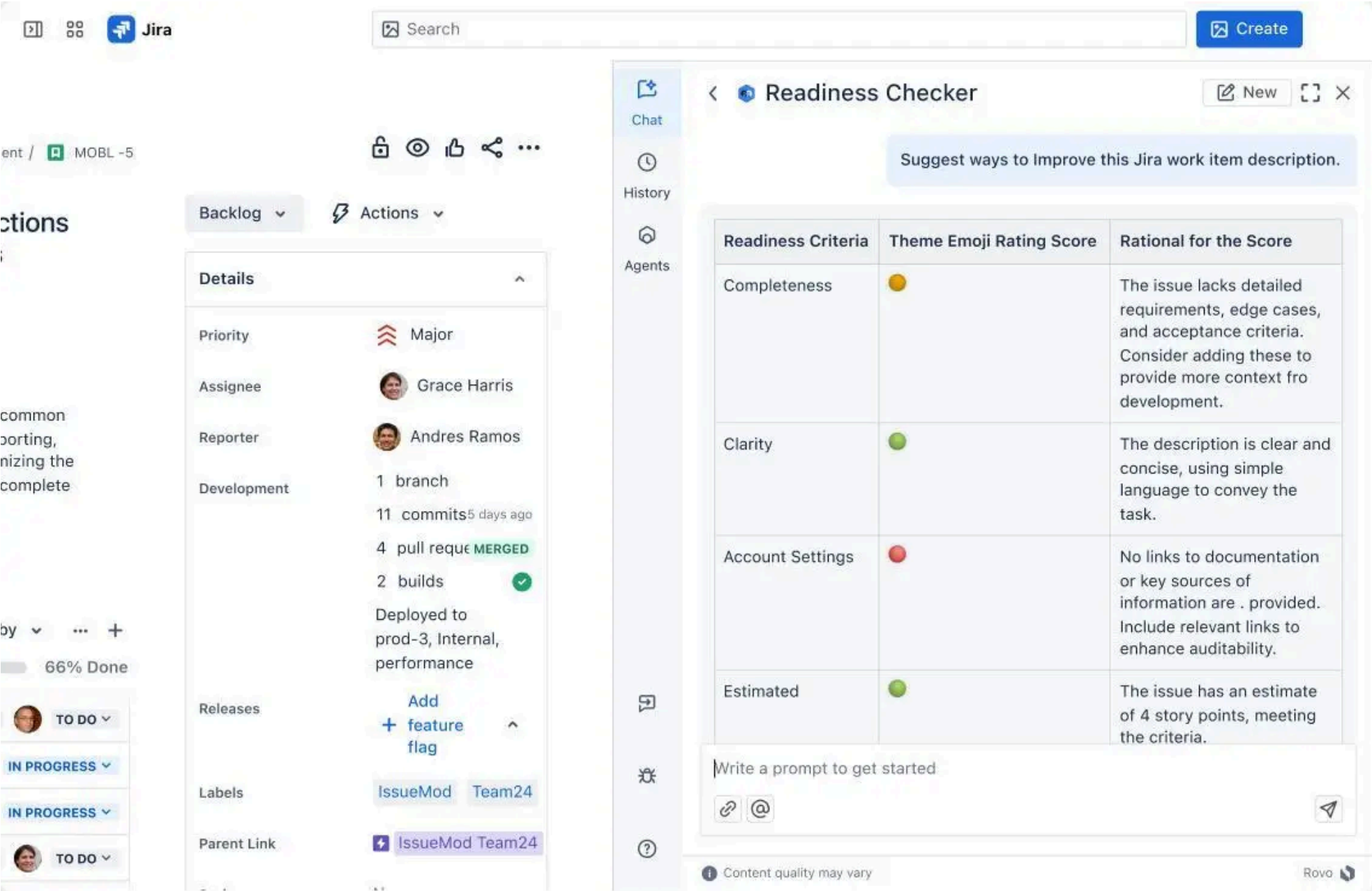
Encourage collaboration during the creation process. Involve the product owner, [software developer](#) (or teams) and other relevant stakeholders to ensure a comprehensive set of criteria that reflects all perspectives.

7. Review and refinement

Don't be afraid to revisit and refine the acceptance criteria throughout development. As understanding evolves, consider adjusting the criteria to reflect the latest information.

8. Provide clarity and concision

Strive for clear and concise language everyone can understand. Technical jargon or ambiguous phrasing can lead to confusion.



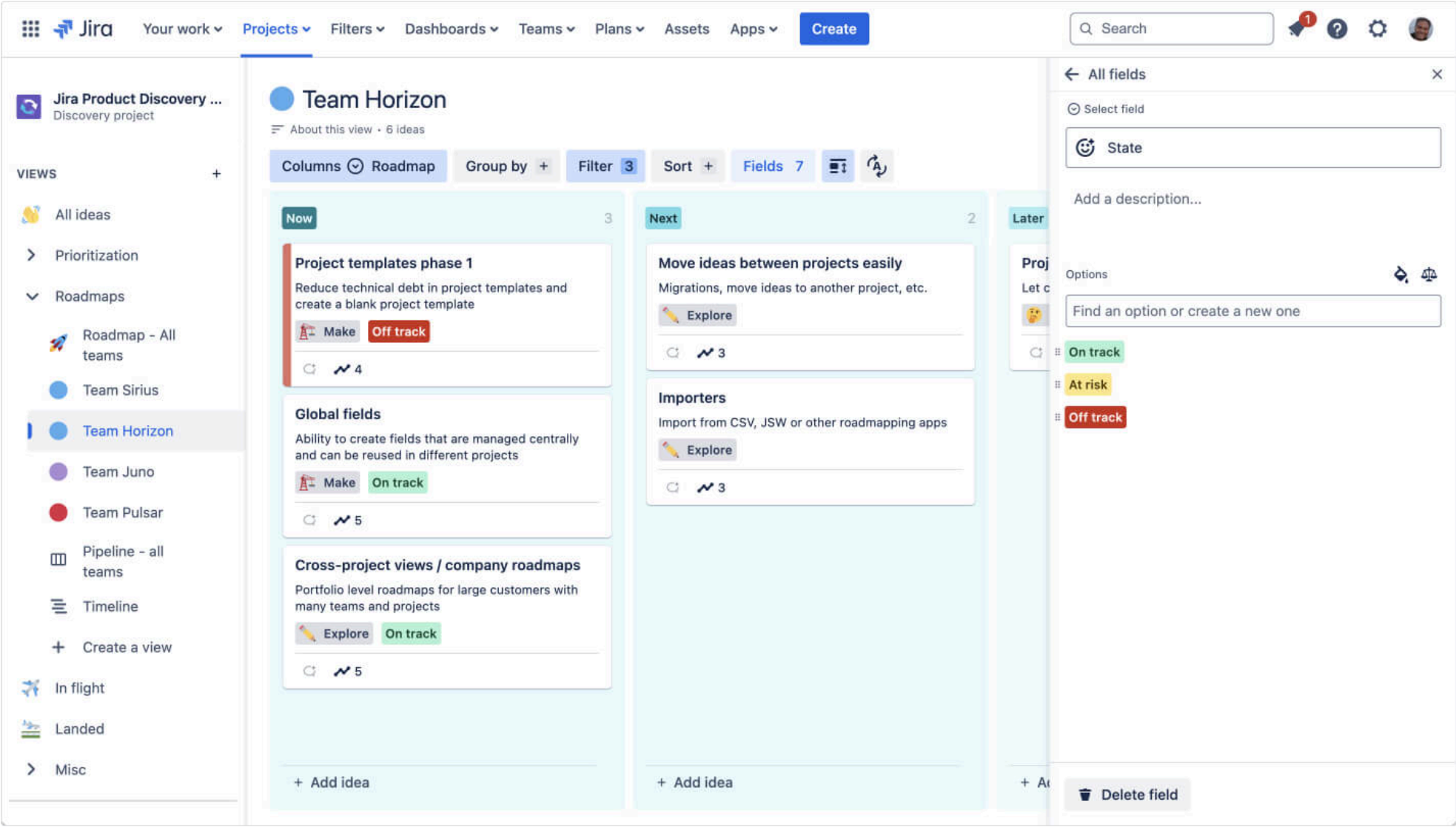
Who should write acceptance criteria?

Writing acceptance criteria in [Agile workflows](#) and methodology environments is a collaborative effort rather than an individual one. Here's a breakdown of the typical roles:

- **Product owner:** Possesses a deep understanding of customer needs and product vision, and plays a crucial role in initiating the discussion and outlining the desired functionality.
- **Development team:** Uses their technical expertise to provide valuable insights into the feasibility and testability of the criteria, and suggest appropriate ways to frame the criteria for clear evaluation.
- **Scrum master (if applicable):** A facilitator who guides the team discussion and ensures everyone has a voice, as well as ensure the criteria adhere to best practices.

While the product owner may initiate the process, the final criteria should be a collective effort that integrates all stakeholder perspectives.

This collaborative approach fosters a shared understanding and increases the likelihood of delivering a successful product.



Examples of acceptance criteria

Below are refined examples of well-written acceptance criteria. Each one clearly connects a user story to specific, measurable conditions that define what “done” looks like.

Example 1: Product search

- **User story:** *As a customer, I want to search for products by name so I can quickly find the items I’m looking for.*
- **Acceptance criteria:**
 - The system returns all products that exactly match the entered search term.
 - The system returns partial matches when the user enters at least three characters.
 - Search results display the product name, image, and price in a clear and organized layout.
 - The search results page supports pagination, displaying a maximum of 20 results per page.
 - If no results are found, the system displays a “No results found” message with helpful next steps.

Example 2: Edit account information

- **User story:** *As a registered user, I want to edit my account information so I can keep my profile up to date.*
- **Acceptance criteria:**
 - Users can access an **Edit Profile** section within their account settings.
 - Users can update their first name, last name, email address, and phone number.
 - The system validates required fields and displays errors for invalid or missing information.
 - Clicking **Save** successfully updates the user’s information in the system.
 - After a successful update, the system displays a confirmation message.
 - If the update fails, the system displays an actionable error message.

Example 3: User activity reporting

- **User story:** *As an administrator, I want to generate activity reports to track user activity and engagement.*
- **Acceptance criteria:**
 - The admin dashboard includes a dedicated **Reports** section.
 - Administrators can generate reports on key user activities, including logins, product views, and purchases.
 - Reports can be filtered by date range and user type.
 - Administrators can export reports in at least two formats, including CSV and PDF.
 - The system displays a clear error message if a report cannot be generated.

These examples demonstrate how strong acceptance criteria transform user stories into actionable, testable requirements. When teams follow this structure, they deliver features that consistently meet user expectations and reduce ambiguity throughout

development.

Write clear acceptance criteria with the help of a centralized platform

When everyone works from a centralized space, it's so much easier to develop, track, and share acceptance criteria. That's why so many teams use [Jira](#) to manage acceptance criteria.

It's simple to place them directly in the story description or Acceptance Criteria field. And Jira's formatting tools, like bullet lists and checkboxes, help teams track progress and keep requirements clear.

Additionally, you can attach designs or link to [Confluence](#) documentation ensures all relevant context is easily accessible. If you need help writing more consistent and complete acceptance criteria, Jira's AI solution Rovo identifies gaps and suggesting improvements.

Together, all of these features and tools reduce ambiguity and support a smoother development process. Get started today.

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Acceptance criteria: Frequently asked questions

What is the difference between acceptance criteria and definition of done?

Acceptance criteria and DoD are crucial for project success, but they serve distinct purposes. Acceptance criteria focus on the specific functionalities a user story must fulfill to be complete for the end user.

DoD establishes a broader set of quality standards for all development work. These encompass non-functional aspects such as code quality and documentation.

Acceptance criteria define what must happen for a user story, while DoD outlines the overall quality standards for how a team completes development work.

When should you write acceptance criteria?

The ideal timing can vary, but there are a few key windows to consider. One option is identifying initial criteria during backlog refinement sessions, where the team discusses and fleshes out user stories.

Another suitable time is during [sprint planning](#) when the team collaboratively finalizes the acceptance criteria for user stories slated for the upcoming sprint. This ensures the criteria are current and reflect the latest understanding.

Define acceptance criteria before development begins to ensure clear expectations and a smooth development process.

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